**The decision came in pretty late, but it had the stamp of public approval. Ten days after the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) won a resounding victory in the Kerala assembly election, winning 102 of the 140 seats, the Congress high command finally announced leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the outgoing assembly, V.D Satheesan, 61, as the state's new chief minister on May 14. He was chosen over two other party veterans—AICC general secretary and Alappuzha MP K.C. Venugopal, a strong contender who reportedly had the backing of a majority of the newly-elected MLAs; and former state home minister and Haripad MLA, Ramesh Chennithala. Satheesan is expected to take oath as CM on May 18.**

Amidst the intense lobbying for the post, Satheesan had the backing of only former Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee chiefs V.M. Sudheeran and K. Muraleedharan as the party brass sweated over the CM aspirants' list. The crucial factors in his favour—the UDF alliance partners, including the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) with 22 seats, who were rooting for him, and the public sentiment back in Kerala. As the deliberations dragged on, support for Satheesan seemed to swell, as also a general feeling that he was being wronged by the 'Delhi cabal'. 'Warning' notices against the Gandhis in Wayanad, people on the street haranguing newly elected Congress MLAs perceived to be favouring Venugopal, impromptu protest marches by partymen in some cities, made it increasingly evident that the five-time MLA from Paravur near Kochi was, as at least two newspapers put it, the 'people's choice'.

There was good reason for it too. Satheesan had been the face of the Opposition since he took over as LoP in 2021 when the state Congress was at its lowest ebb after the bruising defeat to the Left Front. He led the fightback both inside and outside the assembly, taking on the Pinarayi Vijayan government on a range of issues. Meanwhile, what may have also tipped the scales in his favour with the high command is the thought that a grassroots leader as the CM face augurs well for the Congress in Kerala, at a time when both Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi had registered big wins from Wayanad in north Kerala and will need to face voters again.

**As for the cabinet, apart from the various factions among the Congress MLAs, a majority of whom reportedly supported Satheesan's rival for the CM post, there will be the allies to consider**

## CHOPPY POLITICAL WATERS

The next few weeks will be quite a challenge for Satheesan, especially with cabinet formation and allocation of ministries. Apart from the various factions among the Congress MLAs (a majority of whom were given tickets by Venugopal, and hence backed him initially), there will be the allies to consider. The IUML had been talking of a deputy CM post in the run-up to the election, but seems to have put it on the backburner since then. Satheesan will also have to deal with a sulking Chennithala, who has publicly declared that he would not be joining the government in any capacity.

The UDF had stormed to power raising key issues regarding the state's development. Other than its own pre-poll promises, there are also the issues the party had taken up, such as enhanced monthly honorariums for the protesting ASHA workers, clearing the pension dues and salaries of the Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) workers, and others.

On the social front, Satheesan will have to balance the demands of the various religious and caste groups. Any slip-ups and he will play into the hands of an increasingly aggressive BJP, which has for the first time won three assembly seats this election. One of the things the new CM has going for him is his strong secular credentials. Before the election, Satheesan had taken on the top leadership of the Nair Service Society (NSS) and the Sree Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam (SNDP) of the Ezhava community for vitiating the air with their anti-Muslim comments. It was a calculated risk, since Pinarayi and the Left's perceived 'soft Hindutva' moves were becoming a point of discussion. In the event, it cost the Left dearly, while Satheesan emerged as the winner, with a more clearly articulated line against polarising politics. The new chief minister maintains that communal forces, whether organised or unorganised, will not have a say in the affairs of his government, even as one of his key allies is the IUML.